premonition about the ultimately doomed nature of their evangelical quest. In the multi-cultural Mughal court art, no matter the imagery, reigned supreme.

As for the image itself, it was yet again in the field of art that it would have the most palpable and long-lasting effect. The naturalism and sense of perspective that Mughal artists studied through European paintings in Akbar's, and then later in Jahangir's court, would be adapted by them in innovative and creative ways. The 'harvest of heathens' that the Jesuits had fondly dreamed of in Hindustan would remain, at least in the Mughal courts, only a mirage. 'In the conversion of souls,' admitted the Jesuits ruefully, 'there was not so much progress in this land of the (Muslims) who are hard as diamonds to work upon, as in other lands where this sect has not taken root.' It might have helped if the Jesuits, with their obdurate and almost fanatical hatred of other religions, had been able to look within themselves for reasons for their failure. When the diplomatic son of Muzaffar Hussain Mirza of Badakhshan conversationally asked them what they thought of Prophet Muhammad, 'the Father told him that we regard him as one of the greatest imposters that ever entered the world'.

Over the next few months, missives fizzed between Agra and Allahabad, as Akbar tried to reason with his son and understand the cause of his dissatisfaction. In March 1602, Salim intimated that he wanted to visit his father but Akbar decided that his petition 'did not possess the glory of sincerity' and refused his son's request. Ominously, news reached the capital that Salim was headed towards Agra at the head of 30,000 horses, 1,000 elephants, and 2,000 boats. This was no longer an entourage, but an army. By the time Salim had reached Etawah, 100 kilometres from Agra, Akbar sent him an ice-cold message. The prince was either to present himself unattended to his father, else 'his peace and prosperity lay in returning to Allahabad'. Unable to countenance disobeying a direct order from the Padshah, Salim turned around.

One who was assiduously written out of the records was Harkha Bai. It is impossible to know what this Rajput queen felt about this relentless battle between her husband, the Padshah, and her son, Salim, since both Persian and Rajput records are silent on this matter. And the records would remain silent until the time her son became emperor. Up until 1605 she remains elusive, like a half-forgotten dream. But the story of a Mughal Padshah and a Rajput rani proved irresistible to the twentieth century, however, and it